

ROLES

While the player characters are important agents of their House, many of them may intend to distinguish themselves and eventually take a more leading role. Within each House of the Landsraad are several positions that require exceptional talent and loyalty, but offer incredible power and responsibility within the House. While the ruler is the most renowned, they do not survive long without the assistance of such as a spymaster or advisor.

While it is not quite time for your player characters to ascend this high, one day they will. So, each player should take a moment to decide who they serve directly in their House. While they may report directly to the ruler of the House, a spy would mainly serve the Spymaster, a bodyguard the Swordmaster, and a courtier one of the many Advisors. Each player should decide who they report to, and to a certain degree, perhaps even who they intend to one day replace...

A character might not actually be the Heir but might still be a noble looking to prove to the ruler of the House that they are more suited to the task than their elder brother or sister. A Suk doctor might hope to replace the aging Chief Physician of the House when they finally

retire, an assassin might even have a more direct way they intend to take over the position of Master of Assassins. How such promotion is handled depends on the way the House is run, but each character should have an eye on their own advancement.

If the player characters prefer to take on one of these roles themselves, there is little reason not to. It would be a little odd to have such a vital officer of the House working in the field as the player characters do, but it is not unheard of. In a small House Minor there may be little option when they need a good agent. Your group may also prefer a less direct form of gameplay (see **Agents and Architects**, p.7).

In the meantime, following is a list of common roles among the noble Houses. Not every House utilizes every position, and some might have multiple agents serving in the same position (such as Advisor or even Consort). However, the players and gamemaster should take some time to decide which positions are filled in their House and who it is that does so.

Is your Ruler a kindly old grandmother figure or a ruthless general? Is your Spymaster a secretive shadow behind the throne or a jovial raconteur who always seems to know who is doing what to whom?



For those you decide upon, give them a name and a trait or two to bring them to life. While you should determine the Ruler at the very least, if you can't think what to do for any of the other roles, leave them blank and return to them during the game as the details of your House become clearer to your group.

RULER

This is the current leader of the House and bears its name as a surname. They hold a noble title such as Baron/Baroness, Graf/Gräfin, Count/Countess, Margrave/Margravine, Marquis/Marchioness, Duke/Duchess, or similar, and as the head of the House, they have a vote in the Landsraad. Every action performed by the House as a whole is done in the Ruler's name (or in the name of their superiors—the House Major above, or the Emperor). The Ruler makes all the most important decisions regarding the House and appoints others to their roles.

If the Ruler is wed to someone, they share in the title and may also take the role of Ruler if they desire. Whomever inherited the position of Ruler by birth takes precedence out of the two, however, and only one other person may be Ruler (others may take the Consort role instead). There may also be a struggle for power if the Ruler dies and two powerful claimants contest the succession.

Rights & Responsibilities: The Ruler has complete control over the House, and everyone must obey their commands. However, running the House takes all their time, and if they fail in or ignore their duties the House quickly falls apart.

CONSORT

The Consort is the spouse, concubine, or companion of the Ruler, but either cannot or will not take on the role of Ruler themselves. In some cases, the relationship is purely a business one, but many Rulers and Consorts do love and care deeply for each other (such as Duke Leto and Lady Jessica). The Consort can attend court and speak on the Ruler's behalf when they are absent and may serve as Ruler if none is present (such as if the Ruler is dead and the Heir is not yet of age). The Bene Gesserit often place their agents (openly or clandestinely) in such a role. The Ruler would determine the Consort's true standing within the household, and by extension, their ability to speak for the House.

Rights & Responsibilities: The Consort always has the ear of the Ruler and as such has incredible influence behind the throne. This can often lead to others attempting to manipulate them as a means by which to control the Ruler.



ADVISOR

There are many areas of expertise that a Ruler needs to be conversant with. This might be politics, CHOAM business, finance, social etiquette, Imperial history, or a host of other subjects. While a single political advisor is most common, some Houses employ several Advisors in many different areas to grant the Ruler the benefit of their experience. Other Rulers are so well trained (or arrogant) they feel no need for any assistance. The relationship an Advisor has with the Ruler also varies. Some Advisors cover a weakness in the Ruler's education or abilities, other times they are simply a trusted sounding board for the Ruler's ideas. The wealthiest Houses (especially the Imperial House) often employ Bene Gesserit Reverend Mothers in this capacity for their Truthsayer abilities.

Rights & Responsibilities: Each Advisor has a field of knowledge they are expected to be an expert in. It is up to them to keep up-to-date with any changes in that field of knowledge or new discoveries. When the Ruler asks for their understanding of a particular problem, they had better have an answer.

CHIEF PHYSICIAN

Most Houses run a sizable medical staff, which requires coordination and management. However, as the most trusted doctor available, the Chief Physician also personally attends to the health of the ruling family. Maintaining the health of just the household staff and soldiers can require a lot of work. The larger the House, the larger the medical staff needs to be, and more so if the House is at war. The Chief Physician also works closely with the Spymaster to ensure no biological weapons or poisons are used against the House or its ruling family. As such they carefully monitor the health of everyone in the House and perform autopsies on enemy agents to make sure there are no further tricks or traps, such as implanted bombs, yet to be sprung. For reasons of security, Doctors of the Suk school are especially valuable, given their conditioning against doing any form of harm to their charges. However, few, if any, Minor Houses can afford Suk-trained doctors.

Rights & Responsibilities: A Chief Physician is the head of all medical units and staff in the noble House. As the personal doctor to the noble family they are also afforded an incredible amount of trust. In a world of assassins and spies, a doctor who is willing to betray their House can strike at its most vulnerable heart.

COUNCILOR

The Councilor connects the Ruler to the people who serve the House, receiving and sorting through the requests of the citizenry to pass on to the Ruler, and then presenting the Ruler's decisions to the people in ways they can understand. It is the Councilor's responsibility to oversee the minutia of how the House is run, and to see that any problems that need to reach the Ruler's attention get there.

Rights & Responsibilities: The Councilor has their ear to the ground in terms of the ordinary people of the House. They know and understand their needs and can help the Ruler provide for them—or ignore them. They will also be able to determine the mood of the people and whether unrest may be on the horizon.

ENVOY

An Envoy is a diplomat, responsible for the House's foreign policy—that is, the peaceful interactions between the House and their rivals, CHOAM representatives, the Landsraad, or third parties like the Bene Gesserit or the Spacing Guild. They oversee a staff of diplomats, messengers, and ambassadors. It is their responsibility to represent the interests of the House and its Ruler to outsiders.

Rights & Responsibilities: An Envoy needs to have a keen grasp on the state of the universe outside the confines of their House. Imperial politics can shift quickly and the ability to predict those moods can be the key to the House's survival.

HEIR

The Heir is usually the ruler's eldest child, whether by blood or adoption. But some elder children can be passed over for a more competent or conniving younger sibling. A few have even been chosen from non-nobles who prove their worth and impress the Ruler. Only the Ruler may choose who the Heir is. Once nominated, an Heir's time is mostly spent learning how to take on the responsibility of Rulership. As such they may also handle some lesser duties on the Ruler's behalf.

Rights & Responsibilities: An Heir must simply keep themselves safe and be ready to lead the House should the Ruler fall. With assassins around every corner, this may be sooner than they think. An Heir is often a prime target for the enemies of a House, as without one a House can fall to confusion or infighting should the Ruler fall. As such, some devious Rulers openly nominate an Heir they don't like to provide a target, secretly priming another as their real Heir.

MARSHAL

The Marshal ensures that the House's laws are enforced, and that the House's territories are orderly and secure. They often coordinate with others (such as the Councilor) on matters of security, but in matters of law and judgment, they answer only to the Ruler. To be an effective investigator, a Marshal must understand the criminal underworld, either knowing where to root out crime or being on first-name terms with gangsters, working to keep the peace.

Rights & Responsibilities: The Marshal is responsible for maintaining the rule of law within the holdings of the House. They might be a lone sheriff or chief of a large

police force, depending on the size and stability of the House. A corrupt Marshal can seriously damage the productivity of a House, allowing smugglers and crime to funnel funds away from the Ruler.

SCHOLAR

The Scholar is a representative of higher learning, handling matters of science and academia on the Ruler's behalf and advising them on anything they are uninformed about. They are a form of expert Advisor, skilled not in politics but in science and academic discipline. They conduct research and gather information under the Ruler's patronage, with the repositories of knowledge they cultivate advancing the House substantially with new innovations or discoveries.

Rights & Responsibilities: Most Scholars are left to their own devices to simply work on their studies, only being called upon to report their advances or when their specialized knowledge is required. If the projects they are working on are vital to the House, they may be under immense pressure to deliver solutions quickly. This may lead to dangerous mistakes if they are not careful.

SPYMASTER

The Spymaster maintains a network of spies, assassins, and informants at home and elsewhere. It is their job to manage the clandestine espionage activities of the House, in terms of intelligence-gathering and counter-espionage. How underhanded they are about this depends on the needs of the House, but most Spymasters are devious in the extreme and extremely well-informed. Many even keep secrets from their Ruler to allow them to claim 'plausible deniability'.

Some Spymasters focus more exclusively on protecting their House using assassins rather than spies and informants. In this case one is called a 'Master of Assassins' rather than a Spymaster, although the term is not derogatory in any way. Some Houses even employ both a Spymaster and a Master of Assassins.

Rights & Responsibilities: It is up to the Spymaster to protect the House from the threats lurking in the shadows. They should never be surprised by the actions of their enemies, and always have a trap waiting for those who move against their House.

SWORDMASTER

Also known as a 'Weaponsmaster', the title of Swordmaster is an ancient and honorable one. They are an expert in martial matters, serving as a military advisor, tactician, and bodyguard to the Ruler. Most also take a personal hand training the House troops and instructing the Heir how to protect themselves. The personal safety of the noble family is their direct responsibility, and one they take very seriously.

Rights & Responsibilities: A Swordmaster is not only a lethal fighter but a deadly tactician, often with experience honed on several battlefields. They need to be aware of every possible strategy an enemy might use against them and know how to ensure the noble family can be kept safe, no matter what.

TREASURER

The Treasurer is the main financial officer of the House. They monitor the state of the House's funds, oversee tax collection, and handle other financial matters that are part of running the House.

Rights & Responsibilities: A good Treasurer can see a lot of details in the accounts, as discrepancies will reveal corruption, poor management and a host of other problems. They are also good at ensuring the right investments improve the House's financial portfolio. Many work hand-in-hand with CHOAM advisors to maintain the House's position within the Landsraad.

WARMASTER

Where a Swordmaster is an expert in single combat, a Warmaster is the House general. It is their job to lead the House troops into battle, in whatever form that might take. They are the highest-ranking member of the House's military, responsible for raising, maintaining, and commanding the House's troops in both peacetime and during war. They may be a warrior themselves, or more of a leader and strategist, but matters of war are their province.

Rights & Responsibilities: Most Houses manage to get along without open conflict, but when they do engage one another, the battles are brutal and decisive. A Warmaster must be able to defend the House at a moment's notice and plan the logistics of moving troops with speed and efficiency, even to other planets when required.



ENEMIES

Finally, we would be remiss not to mention that your House will have enemies. Even the most pleasant and honorable House has someone that hates them. This might be for some imagined slight or a belief they are not as they appear, but it might just as easily be because they really are honorable and decent and despised for that. One often sees their own failings in the face of one's enemy.

Luckily, such enemies need not be engaged in a deadly kanly vendetta such as between Houses Atreides and Harkonnen. Alliances and enemies can also change, as the politics of the Imperium can be very fluid. A situation that makes two Houses enemies one year might see them making an alliance for mutual benefit when the situation changes the next year.

The player characters' House will probably begin play with an enemy or two. No one gains power in the Imperium without upsetting a few people on the way. How many enemies they have depends on how high the player characters' House has risen.

NUMBER OF ENEMIES

- **Nascent House:** No starting enemy Houses
- **House Minor:** One Minor House
- **House Major:** One Major House and One Minor House that serves them
- **Great House:** One Great House or two Major Houses (or one faction, such as Bene Gesserit, the Imperial Court, etc.) and a host of minor Houses who owe allegiance to one of these enemies.

HATRED

Roll 1D20 for each enemy your player characters' House has, determining how much that enemy hates them and how far out of its way it will go to bring them down.

ROLL HATRED

DISLIKE

1-5

Any interaction with this House is at +1 Difficulty, due to distrust, always thinking the worst.

RIVAL

6-10

The House actively seeks to bring the player characters' House down. They whisper about them at court and spread lies and gossip where they can. They avoid open conflict unless they see an opportunity to make a gain for themselves.

LOATHING

11-15

The House always has some a plan to destroy the player characters' House. However, they won't risk their own resources unless they can do serious damage.

KANLY

16-20

The House has dedicated all its resources to seeing the player characters' House not only fall but be wiped out to the last person. They take any risk if it might see an end to the player characters' House.

HOUSE THREAT

As an enemy House is never far away, the gamemaster may spend 1 point of Threat to make any enemy House appear in the adventure in some fashion, whether in person or merely as a rumor. Their appearance might be part of a plan against the player characters, or they may simply be putting into play a plot of their own. They may even just be taking advantage of a moment of weakness with the player character House.



REASON

There is a reason for this rivalry, although the details may be lost to history in some cases. Either roll 1D20 on the list below or choose a reason that makes sense to the group. Note that the player characters' House is not necessarily the injured party! They may just as easily be the aggressor or the House whose bad behavior caused the rift.

ROLL REASON

COMPETITION

1-2

The House is in competition for a resource or place in the market and needs the other House out of the way to take control. This resource might be a particular holding, monopoly of a business area, or even a planet or moon.

SLIGHT

3-4

Something the player character House did at court caused them a loss of reputation or an embarrassment. However, a simple apology isn't good enough to repair their damaged honor.

DEBT

5-6

They or the player character's House has reneged on a deal. This might be through a misunderstanding, an unfortunate circumstance, or just because they could.

ANCIENT FEUD

7-8

The Houses have been enemies for thousands of years. Something one or more of their ancestors did caused a rift that has only widened as the centuries have passed. It is possible no one remembers what the cause was, although both Houses have their own version of the truth.

MORALITY

9-10

Something about the House sickens the other. They might encourage loose morals or a brutal regime but might just as easily be sickeningly loyal to the Emperor, honorable to a fault, or annoying in their religious dedication.

SERVITUDE

11-12

One of the Houses used to serve the other and now owes no fealty. The master House might want to return the 'upstart' to their 'rightful place', or the vassal House might seek revenge for being held back or badly treated.

FAMILY TIES

13-14

The Houses have intermarried throughout the years, but one House has refused to continue the tradition. The issue has divided each House, for which they both blame each other.

ROLL REASON

THEFT

15-16

Something one House has acquired used to belong to the other House. While the possessor insists the item came to them fairly, the other House insists nothing could be further from the truth. The coveted item might be an ancient artifact, piece of advanced technology, a title, or even something more abstract like the favor of the Emperor. Both Houses have passed the point where simply returning the item, if possible, can solve their differences.

JEALOUSY

17-18

One House hates the other for no better reason than they want to be them. They idolize the other House to such a degree it has turned to festering jealousy. They believe the other House unworthy of the amazing benefits it possesses, or they feel that it has squandered all its gifts. If only the jealous House had everything the other has taken for granted, they would have done so much better.

NO REASON

19-20

No one knows why these Houses are rivals, including them. They just are. Only a few among each House might even question the situation.

Example: As a House Minor, House Molay has only one enemy, which they decide to call House Arcuri. In determining the degree of hatred, the players roll a 12, meaning that the Houses loathe each other. Next, they determine the reason for this hatred, and roll a 9, indicating a difference in morality. As House Molay are both poets and assassins, the players decide their enemy House is quite religiously puritanical. After some deliberation, the players and gamemaster decide that House Arcuri has uncovered rumors about House Molay training assassins and so believe them to be not only a force for artistic decadence but corruption as well.

Once your group has determined the nature of any enemy House or Houses, the gamemaster can then use this information to determine more detail, using the same methods as for generating player character Houses. However, with the gamemaster's permission, your group could continue to work together to define everything about their enemies, to the same degree they have done about their own House.





CHAPTER 4: CREATING YOUR CHARACTER

"There are countless definitions and interpretations of a life well spent, and of the opposite. There are often widely divergent biographies of a particular person. The same individual can be either demon or saint, and even shades of both."

—from "The Wisdom of Muad'Dib", by the Princess Irulan

Now that you know something about the House your character serves, we can move on to creating the character. In this chapter we will walk you through the steps for you and your group to create the agents of your House: your player characters. This can be done in a couple of ways: following a number of steps in order to produce a character, or only partially creating a character before play and allowing their nature to be revealed in play.

Characters in *Dune: Adventures in the Imperium* are divided into a two main types: player characters and non-player characters:

PLAYER CHARACTERS

This chapter deals primarily with player characters and how to create and advance them. A player character is any character directly controlled by one of the players, rather than by the gamemaster. Player characters are split into main characters and supporting characters.

Main characters are each player's first and most important character. Each player has a single main character, and these characters are collectively the focus of the adventures you'll play and the stories you'll tell in the Known Universe of Dune. They're the protagonists of the story and will normally be prominent members or agents of a noble House (though not the leaders of the House... yet). This chapter provides two different methods for creating main characters, but whichever method is chosen, it is recommended that the players all use the same method.

Supporting characters are player characters too, but they're less-developed than main characters and are intended to be created quickly during the game as-and-when needed to fulfil a particular role needed by the group. These supporting characters represent other officials and agents of the House and its allies, as well as servants, vassals, and other subordinates such as soldiers and spies. Supporting characters can be either notable or minor:

- ✧ A **notable** supporting character is likely to be a significant recurring character, and they will be capable specialists in their own right.
- ✧ **Minor** supporting characters are the ordinary rank and file subordinates and servants of the House; quick to create and disposable for brief scenes where their skills are necessary.



NON-PLAYER CHARACTERS

Non-player characters, also called NPCs, are characters controlled by the gamemaster, rather than by one of the players. While many non-player characters will be friendly or neutral to the players, the ones which will get the most attention in play are enemies or rivals of the player characters. Non-player characters are major, notable, or minor.

- ✧ **Major NPCs** are important, powerful people, equivalent or superior to the player characters.
- ✧ **Notable NPCs** are significant experts and agents of rival Houses or other factions, similar to notable supporting characters.
- ✧ **Minor NPCs** are the incidental enemies: servants, criminals, soldiers, and other persons unlikely to be identified by name.

Non-player characters are similar to player characters in a number of ways, but they are addressed in **Chapter 8: Gamemastering** and **Chapter 9: Allies and Adversaries**.

WHO ARE YOU?

When creating any character, the first step is to devise a concept for the character: who are they, what do they do? You may want to look through the archetypes described later in this chapter, take an idea from one of the concepts below, or select something else inspired by the universe of *Dune*. It's helpful to keep this concept relatively vague when you start creating a character, as it gives you room to change and adapt.

Some sample concepts include:

- ✧ **Scion of the House:** You are kin to the House's rulers and may even be a potential heir to the House and its fortunes. You may be seeking your place in the Known Universe or looking to prove yourself to earn an inheritance.
- ✧ **Mentat Advisor:** A graduate of the Mentat school, your ability to recall and reason are a vital resource for anyone seeking to hold or gain power, and you serve your House to the best of that ability.
- ✧ **Bene Gesserit Agent:** You're a Sister of the Bene Gesserit, and may serve as a consort or concubine, a diplomat, a spy, or any other role the Sisterhood has commanded you to perform.
- ✧ **Swordmaster:** You're a warrior first and foremost, a master—or aspiring master—of the blade, brought to the House to fight for them or to teach your art to the House's scions and soldiers.
- ✧ **Physician:** For the powerful, there is nothing so vital as health and longevity, so doctors are valuable...

and dangerous. Those of the Suk school are prized for their conditioning that prevents them from betraying their patients, but their services are highly sought-after and not every House can afford them.

- ☞ **Smuggler:** The dominance of CHOAM and the Spacing Guild still allow for goods and people to be moved in the gaps between the great powers of the universe. You're one of those people who work in those gaps, skilled in the illicit-but-vital movement away from the gaze of the powerful.
- ☞ **Fremen Warrior:** You're a hardened survivor, well-versed in water discipline and the other necessary skills for living on Arrakis. You have little reason to trust off-worlders, but circumstances may lead you to stand beside them for a time.
- ☞ **House Officer:** You serve the House, conveying orders to the soldiers who fight the House's battles and leading them by your example.

This basic concept will be refined and changed throughout character creation, whichever method you select, but it provides inspiration for the choices you'll make later.

TWO METHODS

We provide two methods for creating a main character, discussed in their own sections later in this chapter. These methods are as follows:

PLANNED CREATION

This method involves going through several steps, making decisions at each step. You'll choose an archetype for your character, assign points to your skills, choose focuses and talents, select your drives and create your drive statements, and end up with a fully-formed character at the end of the process.

This method allows a player to start with the kind of character they want to play from the outset, and the process allows for a considerable amount of customization of characters.

CREATION IN PLAY

Creation in play is like planned creation, but you make fewer decisions. You make only a few key choices, such as an archetype, a couple of your skills, one of your drives and one drive statement, and leave the rest blank on your character sheet. The rest of the details will be defined once play has begun—at particular points during the game, you may choose to define one of those elements, choosing a skill rating, a drive, a drive statement, a focus, or a talent to add to your character.

This allows play to begin more quickly, and characters to be developed during the game as they face challenges and overcome obstacles. This is often handy for groups who are less familiar with the system, as it allows them to make choices as they become accustomed to the way the game works rather than having to create a complete character before they start playing.

BASIC RULES OVERVIEW

Before you begin creating a character you should know a little about the rules system, so that you know what all the numbers mean. We'll go into all the details later in the book, but all those complications basically boil down to the following.

For the most part, when you want your character to do or say something, you can just describe what they are doing. However, when their actions might prove a test of their skill or abilities, or conflict with someone else, you need to make a **test** to determine the outcome. The game would get pretty boring if you always succeeded at everything you did.

Making a test involves rolling twenty-sided dice (or d20s). When you make a test, roll several of these (from 2 to 5) and gain 1 **success** for each one that rolls equal to or less than the **target number**. This **target number** is calculated by adding up the **skill** you are using (rated 4-8) and the **drive** that is driving the character's actions (also rated 4-8).

If any of your d20s rolls a 1 it counts as 2 successes. The same applies if the result is equal to or under your skill, provided you have an applicable **focus** (a type of specialty) you can apply to the test. This result is called a **critical**. Unfortunately, if any die rolls a '20' your character will suffer a problem (such as a wound) called a **complication** that will make further rolls harder.

The gamemaster will set a **Difficulty** rating from 0 to 5, and if you roll as many successes as the Difficulty your test is a success.

Several factors can help you achieve more successes. **Momentum** points can be spent to roll more d20s, and can be replenished by doing especially well on skill tests. Your character's **traits** might help reduce the Difficulty, and you can use the limited **Determination** points you have to re-roll dice or automatically gain successes. However, the gamemaster has a pool of Threat points they can use to enhance their non-player characters and make the situation more dangerous for the player characters.

THE MEASURE OF A CHARACTER

Player characters in ***Dune: Adventures in the Imperium*** are a cut above most people. They are those who are the most definitively human, those whose discernment and judgment overrule base instinct. In short, they are those most fit to hold positions of status, and to shape the existences of others with their deeds.

Each character is composed of several elements, which serve to represent and define who the character is and how they interact with the worlds they inhabit. These elements are described in the following sections.

PERSONAL TRAITS

A character has two traits, which are essential descriptions of the character. These traits provide a context for a character's actions, influencing the difficulty of the tasks they attempt, and they help you and the game-master determine what is possible or impossible for the character to attempt. In this way, they are no different than the traits the gamemaster describes when they set a new scene, described in **Chapter 5: Core Rules**.

A character's first trait is normally their title, status, or role in society. A character's place in society shapes how they move through society, and influences what they can and cannot do. A character's first trait should always mention the House to which the character belongs or serves. Examples include 'Duke of House Atreides', 'House Atreides' Master of Assassins', or 'Consort to Duke Leto Atreides'.

A character's second trait is more personal, taking the form of the character's reputation such as 'Just and Wise' or 'Callous and Ruthless'. It is how the character is perceived by others, and thus influences how others approach and regard them, for better or worse.

These two traits paint a very basic picture of who the character is and how they fit into the Known Universe. Think of these as being the way you'd describe the character to a person out of game. They are the foremost details about who the character is.

Occasionally, a character may have a third trait; this might reflect a secondary affiliation or loyalty, which may pull the character in a different direction or denote another source of connections and status, such as 'Suk Doctor', or 'Mentat Conditioning', or 'Bene Gesserit Sister'.

SKILLS

Of course, characters are more than just their position and their drives. Accomplishments come from action, and action requires capability. A character's training and expertise are necessary parts of what allows them to influence the world around them.

Each character has a rating in each of five skills, which are described below. Skills contribute to a character's tests, and they define what a character is doing when they act. Each skill is rated from 4 to 8, and the more proficient a character is, the higher the skill is rated.

BATTLE

Battle describes a character's skill at arms, their awareness of danger, their understanding of tactics and strategy, and their knowledge of the tools, techniques, and history of combat.

- ☞ Use **Battle** when you fight, when you seek to avoid danger, when you plan a battle, and when you try to recall some fact about the methods or history of conflict.

COMMUNICATE

Communicate describes a character's ability to skillfully engage in conversations, discussions, and debates. It encompasses the use of implication, innuendo, subtext, and context to convey or hide intent and to read those methods when others use them.

- ☞ Use **Communicate** when you attempt to persuade or deceive others, when you need to convey meaning through implication and subtle means, when you need to understand what others are truly trying to say, and when you need to detect attempts by others to use these methods.

DISCIPLINE

Discipline describes a character's ability to influence and control their own mind and body (overruling instincts and autonomic functions) as well as their ability to exert direct, overt influence over others through presence, force of will, and the power of authority. It also allows a character to focus and concentrate on a complex task, such as picking a lock.

- ☞ Use **Discipline** when attempting to resist attempts to subvert body or mind, such as poisons, drugs, or mental influence, as well as to suppress instincts and reflexes when subjected to extreme pain or hardship, or to compel or threaten others through presence and authority alone.

MOVE

Move describes a character's mobility, their ability to maneuver around an environment quickly or carefully, and their ability to overcome physical obstacles.

- ☞ Use **Move** to walk, run, jump, climb, swim, or otherwise maneuver in situations where speed, precision, stealth, or care are necessary, or when you need to exert physical force in ways other than fighting.

UNDERSTAND

Understand describes a character's ability to take in and process information, and to recall and apply that knowledge effectively at a later point. It also includes logical deduction and intuitive comprehension of situations, forming conclusions from perceived facts, as well as in-depth comprehension of academic, technical, or scientific knowledge.

- ☞ Use **Understand** when attempting to discern details about the situation around you, to search an area thoroughly and effectively, to perform research, to recall things you have learned in the past, to reach conclusions and deductions from the things you know and have learned, and to be able to apply your knowledge and available data in practical ways.

SKILL RATING	MEANING
4	You lack training or knowledge in this field.
5	You're trained to a basic level.
6	You are well-trained, or you have basic training and some experience.
7	You're highly capable and experienced.
8	You are a master of that skill, renowned for your expertise.

FOCUSES

A character's skills are broad, and each character has a selection of focuses which allow you to demonstrate their specialties and the kinds of advanced expertise that comes with specialized training or hard-won experience.

Focuses increase a character's chances of scoring a critical success on tests using that skill, in circumstances where that focus applies. There is no singular, fixed list of focuses. Focuses can be chosen freely during character creation, for there are innumerable areas of expertise and specializations.

In play, while you receive focuses for particular skills, they may be used on any skill test where they might reasonably be appropriate: the skill a focus is listed alongside is simply the skill most likely to use that focus. Where a focus requires you to specify something in particular (all marked with a *) you may only apply your focus to that particular choice. But you may take the focus multiple times to have a collection of different specialties (such as picking Music twice to play two instruments).

EXAMPLE BATTLE FOCUSES

- ☞ **Assassination** (attempting to get close to attack a target)
- ☞ **Atomics** (use and understanding of atomic weapons see p.23 and p.200)
- ☞ **Dirty Fighting** (brawling and fighting with improvised weapons)
- ☞ **Dueling** (duel etiquette and technique)
- ☞ **Evasive Action** (dodging and avoiding blows)
- ☞ **Lasgun** (use of laser weapons see p.23 and p.200)
- ☞ **Long Blades** (use of swords)
- ☞ **Pistols** (Use of firearms and pneumatic weapons, such as maula pistols and dartguns).
- ☞ **Rifle** (Use of non-lasgun rifle weapons).
- ☞ **Shield fighting** (using shields and bypassing them)
- ☞ **Short Blades** (use of knives)
- ☞ **Sneak Attacks** (ambush attacks)
- ☞ **Strategy** (battlefield conflict)
- ☞ **Tactics** (small scale unit conflict)
- ☞ **Unarmed Combat** (fighting without a weapon)

EXAMPLE COMMUNICATE FOCUSES

- ☞ **Acting** (pretending to be something you are not)
- ☞ **Bartering** (reducing the cost of a good or service)
- ☞ **Charm** (befriending others and appearing trustworthy)
- ☞ **Deceit** (lying and plotting)
- ☞ **Diplomacy** (negotiating a deal)
- ☞ **Disguise** (appearing to be something you are not)
- ☞ **Empathy** (understanding the emotional responses of others)
- ☞ **Gossip** (knowing commonly discussed rumors in your local area)
- ☞ **Innuendo** (implying something without saying it, often to communicate a plot to only a few people in earshot)
- ☞ **Inspiration** (using a spark or artistic ability to create something)
- ☞ **Interrogation** (eliciting information from a target, subtly or with threats)
- ☞ **Intimidation** (forcing another to back down)
- ☞ **Linguistics** (languages and the study of the nature of language)
- ☞ **Listening** (overhearing quiet sounds and hidden conversations)
- ☞ **Music*** (specify a particular instrument: harp, baliset, drum, etc)
- ☞ **Neurolinguistics** (planting an idea in someone without their knowledge)
- ☞ **Persuasion** (getting someone to agree to a particular action)
- ☞ **Secret Language*** (specify which faction's secret language you know)
- ☞ **Teaching** (the ability to explain things quickly and simply)

EXAMPLE DISCIPLINE FOCUSES

- ☞ **Command** (giving orders and getting them followed)
- ☞ **Composure** (staying calm in a stressful situation)
- ☞ **Espionage** (spycraft, intelligence gathering, following a target)
- ☞ **Infiltration** (gaining access to an area or faction)

- ❑ **Observe** (paying attention to a person or area to gain intelligence)
- ❑ **Precision** (performing a complex task dexterously)
- ❑ **Resolve** (resisting environmental danger)
- ❑ **Self-Control** (remaining in control of your feelings or actions)
- ❑ **Survival*** (specific to an environment: Desert, Jungle, Arctic, Urban, etc.)

EXAMPLE MOVE FOCUSES

- ❑ **Acrobatics** (tumbling and swinging)
- ❑ **Body Control** (lowering heart rate, slowing breathing, etc.)
- ❑ **Climb** (climbing surfaces)
- ❑ **Dance** (knowing how to dance and performing as a dancer)
- ❑ **Distance Running** (running a marathon)
- ❑ **Drive** (operating a ground vehicle)
- ❑ **Escaping** (freeing yourself of bonds)
- ❑ **Grace** (moving with poise and style)
- ❑ **Pilot*** (specific type of craft)
- ❑ **Stealth** (moving without being seen)
- ❑ **Swift** (moving quickly)
- ❑ **Swim** (swimming in any environment)
- ❑ **Unobtrusive** (staying hidden when in plain sight)
- ❑ **Worm Rider** (calling and riding a worm - Fremen only)

EXAMPLE UNDERSTAND FOCUSES

- ❑ **Advanced Technology** (making repairs and crafting machines)
- ❑ **Botany** (study of plants)
- ❑ **CHOAM Bureaucracy** (understanding CHOAM legal systems and operations)
- ❑ **Cultural Studies** (understanding non-Imperium cultures)
- ❑ **Danger Sense** (knowing when a situation feels wrong)

- ❑ **Data Analysis** (collating and cross-referencing information)
- ❑ **Deductive reasoning** (making assumptions based on current information)
- ❑ **Ecology** (understanding of planetary ecological systems)
- ❑ **Emergency Medicine** (first aid and basic life saving)
- ❑ **Etiquette** (knowing the rules of good society)
- ❑ **Faction Lore*** (specify Bene Gesserit, Spacing Guild, Tleilaxu, etc.)
- ❑ **Genetics** (the study of genetic data)
- ❑ **Geology** (the study of rocks and land)
- ❑ **House Politics** (understanding the history and relationship between the Houses)
- ❑ **Imperial Politics** (the state, history, and organization of the Imperial court)
- ❑ **Infectious Diseases** (understanding disease)
- ❑ **Kanly** (knowledge of the accepted forms of vendetta)
- ❑ **Philosophy** (knowing how to debate philosophical thought)
- ❑ **Physical Empathy** (understanding a person's state from their body language)
- ❑ **Physics** (the physical systems of the universe)
- ❑ **Poison** (the study, effects, and use of poisons)
- ❑ **Psychiatry** (knowing the human mind)
- ❑ **Religion** (understanding the Orange Catholic bible and the study of religion in general)
- ❑ **Smuggling** (knowing the best ways to evade customs authorities)
- ❑ **Surgery** (performing surgical techniques)
- ❑ **Traps** (constructing and avoiding physical traps and explosive devices)
- ❑ **Virology** (the study of viruses and immunology)



DRIVES

A character's inner life motivates and defines their actions. A character's drives, thus, shape the things they do, and how successful they are at those things. A character is more likely to succeed when they believe strongly in something, and less likely when they are indifferent. But those strong drives can also lead a character into trouble or lead them to take ill-advised actions.

Each character has a rating in each of five drives, which are described below. Drives are added to a character's skills to derive the target number when they attempt a test. But they also define why a character is taking action, and what drives them to succeed. A character's most important drive is rated 8. The second-most is rated at 7, then the rest at 6, 5, and 4.

Which drive applies to a test is usually defined by which drive statement applies to the action. But sometimes players may wish to speed up play by directly selecting the right drive and looking to see if its statement applies.

DUTY

Duty is the pressure upon a character to find their place in society and fulfill their allotted role, but also the weight of obligations and personal responsibilities.

- ☞ Use **Duty** when it is your character's responsibility to get the job done, and when others are counting on the character to succeed. This might be in service to their House or the people under their command.

FAITH

Faith is the moral expectation of religion and a character's spiritual needs. It shows their dedication to a higher power and the guiding hand of destiny. But a high Faith drive does not always mean a religious or spiritual dedication, as some place their faith in their faction or friends as much as the will of God.

- ☞ Use **Faith** when the character has a moral imperative to take action, whether from their religion or personal values. This might also be used to rely on luck or a last-minute plan for an action to succeed.

JUSTICE

Justice is a drive toward balance and fairness, but also the will to redress injustices. It often serves the law and the common good, but it can just as easily uphold bad laws and be used as an excuse for revenge.

- ☞ Use **Justice** when doing the action is simply the right thing to do, legally if not morally. This might be when the character is enforcing the law, when they are meting out punishment on behalf of their House, or even when taking revenge.

POWER

Power is the pursuit of greater influence, authority, or control over the universe around them. It is the character's ego, representing their belief in their own moral authority and their right to take what they want.

- ☞ Use **Power** when doing the action serves the character's agenda in some way, either directly or indirectly. Self-serving actions need not always take from others and might even require sacrifice (for a greater reward), but they are never entirely altruistic.

TRUTH

Truth is the desire for knowledge and the need to uncover or define that which is true. It is dedicated to revealing the right answers, even if they are uncomfortable or even dangerous.

- ☞ Use **Truth** when the character's curiosity has got the better of them, or when they absolutely must know the answer to enhance their own knowledge and understanding. It is also useful when uncovering secrets.

Players often try and pick their highest drive as often as possible. This is perfectly fine, as their character will naturally try to play to their strength. But the gamemaster may decide this makes them predictable and grant their enemies an appropriate bonus. Sometimes the gamemaster may also rule that certain situations insist on certain drives, or even preclude them.

A drive being important (and thus having a high rating) can be either positive or negative: a character with a Truth rating of 8 may be scrupulously honest, or they may seek to impose their own version of the truth upon others or control what others know.

DRIVE RATING	MEANING
-----------------	---------

4	You care very little about this thing.
---	--

5	You know that this thing matters, but you have other priorities.
---	--

6	This is certainly something that influences you.
---	--

7	This is a high priority for you.
---	----------------------------------

8	This is the single most important thing for you.
---	--

DRIVE STATEMENTS

For each drive with a rating of 6 or higher, you define a single statement. This is a short sentence explaining what the character feels about that drive. Characters don't have drive statements for their lower-rated drives, because they don't feel strongly enough about those things.

Some example drive statements are below, for each drive:

EXAMPLE DUTY STATEMENTS

- ❑ "People are the true strength of a Great House."
- ❑ "I serve at the pleasure of the House."
- ❑ "Humans live best when each has their place."
- ❑ "Acceptance of place is the death of freedom."
- ❑ "Those above offer duty to those below."
- ❑ "I know my responsibilities."
- ❑ "Duty is a sharp blade."
- ❑ "What must be done, must be done."

EXAMPLE FAITH STATEMENTS

- ❑ "My faith gives me certainty where others might doubt."
- ❑ "Faith is merely obedience to the myths of the past."
- ❑ "God will deliver me to whatever fate is mine."
- ❑ "Machines are things of corruption."
- ❑ "I trust my heart, not my head."
- ❑ "Our trials are how God tests us."
- ❑ "Those who doubt my faith will be proved wrong."
- ❑ "God has forgotten us for we are not worthy."

EXAMPLE JUSTICE STATEMENTS

- ❑ "I must shield those in my care."
- ❑ "I will get revenge on those who have wronged me."
- ❑ "I have no patience for those who complain that life is unfair."

- ❑ "What we do will return to us."
- ❑ "Life isn't fair."
- ❑ "Justice is what you can get away with."
- ❑ "Justice is only for the wealthy."
- ❑ "Everyone should be treated equally."

EXAMPLE POWER STATEMENTS

- ❑ "Power must be used wisely and cleverly."
- ❑ "The power to destroy a thing is the absolute control over it."
- ❑ "All power invites challenge."
- ❑ "Those who have true power need seldom wield it."
- ❑ "Power attracts those who are corruptible."
- ❑ "Power comes at a knife's edge."
- ❑ "I will have what is owed to me."
- ❑ "Strength is nothing without grace."

EXAMPLE TRUTH STATEMENTS

- ❑ "Respect for the truth comes close to being the basis for all morality."
- ❑ "I decide what is true."
- ❑ "I seek to uncover the many secrets of the universe."
- ❑ "If I do not know it, it is irrelevant."
- ❑ "The purpose of argument is to change the nature of truth."
- ❑ "What one wishes were true is seldom so."
- ❑ "You will know me by my deeds."
- ❑ "Truth is the first casualty of war."



If a character wishes to use a drive which has an accompanying drive statement, then their action must align with the statement. If a character attempts to use a drive with a statement that clashes with the action they're attempting, then they may suffer complications or be required to give up that drive statement, as described in **Chapter 5: Core Rules**.

AMBITION

The ability to form goals beyond the immediate, visceral needs of life is a powerful part of human nature, and those who harness this ability to aspire, who can suppress their short-term desires in service to greater achievements, are those who prosper in a ruthless universe.

As a result, each player character has an ambition which guides their long-term actions. A character who takes steps to achieve their ambitions becomes more capable, able to influence others or impose their wills more effectively.

A character's ambition is a short phrase describing their ultimate goal or desire, and it is defined by their highest-rated drive at the time of character creation. Your gamemaster will work with you to define one for your character.

- Duty ambitions are about service to a cause or group, discovering or understanding one's place

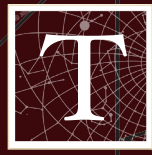
in the universe, or freedom from the strictures and responsibilities that constrain you.

- Faith ambitions are zealous crusades, spiritual fulfillment, matters of prophecy or destiny, or attempts to undermine or destroy those things.
- Justice ambitions are driven by a sense of fairness or balance, or a desire to right wrongs and injustices... including personal grudges and vendettas.
- Power ambitions are about gaining influence or status, taking those things from others, manipulating those with influence or status, or changing the ways that people gain influence or status.
- Truth ambitions often include uncovering knowledge or revealing secrets, concealing knowledge or protecting secrets, spreading knowledge (including propaganda or misinformation), or exposing the lies of others.

A character's ambition can change over time. If a character's highest-rated drive changes, then you may change the character's ambition as well. You don't have to make this change if you don't want to—a person's goals may remain the same even as their worldview shifts—but if the drive which the ambition was based on ever drops to less than 6 (and thus loses its statement), you must change the ambition.



PLANNED CHARACTER CREATION



his method is designed for players to create their characters before the game begins. It's recommended that players create characters together, as a group; this will allow the players to discuss their concepts, bounce ideas off one another, and come up with ideas for how the characters know and interact with one another—are they friends, polite colleagues, rivals for their masters' esteem, or virtual strangers? As the characters all work for the same House, they already have a natural reason to work together, and creating characters together can follow on naturally from House creation.

CHARACTER CREATION SUMMARY

STEP ONE: CONCEPT

Consider your character idea.

Select a faction template if applicable and record its trait if you do.

STEP TWO: ARCHETYPE

Choose or adapt an archetype from the list. Record its trait.

STEP THREE: SKILLS

Assign a rating to each skill:

- ☐ The primary skill listed for your archetype is rated at 6.
- ☐ The secondary skill listed for your archetype is rated at 5.
- ☐ The other three skills are rated at 4.
- ☐ Add 5 more points among your skills, to a maximum of 8.

STEP FOUR: FOCUSES

Choose four focuses and assign them to skills (listing on p.103). At least one should be assigned to your primary skill. Your archetype will offer suggestions you may take if you wish.

STEP FIVE: TALENTS

Choose three talents. Each archetype suggests one talent.

Faction characters must pick all mandatory talents but otherwise have a free choice for any remaining picks.

STEP SIX: DRIVES AND DRIVE STATEMENTS

Rank the five drives in order of importance, assigning the ratings 8, 7, 6, 5, and 4 among them, with 8 being the most important.

Assign a drive statement to the three highest drives. Some suggestions can be found on p.106.

STEP SEVEN: ASSETS

Your character begins play with three assets, one of which must be tangible.

STEP EIGHT: FINISHING TOUCHES

- ☐ **Trait** – Choose a trait based on your character's reputation or personality.
- ☐ **Ambition** – Decide on a goal for your character, related to their highest drive.
- ☐ **Personal Details** – Decide on a name, personality, appearance, and relationships.

STEP ONE: CONCEPT

The first step in creating a player character is to decide what general sort of character to create. You may want to look through the archetypes described later in this chapter, from one of the concepts mentioned in the introduction, or something else inspired by the universe of *Dune*. It's helpful to keep this concept relatively vague at this stage, as it gives you room to change and adapt.

Once you have a concept that you're happy with, move on to the next step.

FACTION CHARACTERS AND TEMPLATES

It's assumed that the majority of player characters will be ordinary people, working for the group's House and capable enough to have achieved some degree of standing and importance, but otherwise typical of the people who inhabit the Imperium.

But that won't be the case for all player characters. Some of the most iconic characters in *Dune* are part of a faction outside the system of noble Houses. You may wish to play a Sister of the Bene Gesserit, a Mentat, an agent of the Spacing Guild, a Suk doctor, or one of the desert-dwelling Fremen of Arrakis. All of these characters will be loyal to the noble House the player characters serve, but they have other loyalties and ties that cannot be ignored. They also possess some of the most advanced training and abilities in the Imperium, so care must be taken to ensure they don't overshadow the other player characters.

Players can pick one of these faction options to add to their concept, and doing so doesn't alter character creation very much. But as the training of such characters is very specific, some of the players' choices will be limited. The benefit is that it grants access to further powerful abilities and connections. Faction characters shouldn't be chosen lightly or on a whim, and their faction should be a core part of the concept from the outset. Until they prove themselves, their absolute loyalty to the House will often be questioned.

If you do opt to play a faction character, the following additional rules apply. These are summarized in a template for each faction option below.

1. The character has an additional bonus trait, reflecting their other affiliation. This is listed on the faction template. For example, 'Bene Gesserit Sister', or 'Mentat', or 'Fremen', etc.
2. The character then selects their archetype as normal. Some may be especially suitable, though, and each template offers some suggestions. But the player is still free to choose any archetype.
3. Each faction template has at least one 'mandatory talent'. This talent can be selected in place of any other talent the player might pick, but it must be taken by the end of character creation. It represents essential training the faction character must complete to gain further abilities.

It should also be noted that no character can take more than a single faction template for their character. There are no Face Dancer/Mentats or Bene Gesserit/Guild Agents.

Example: Claire and her group are creating characters who will all be agents of House Molay. Claire likes the idea of playing a Bene Gesserit Sister but doesn't want to be too tied to the Sisterhood. So, she decides to play a noblewoman who was trained by the Sisterhood as a girl. Her character, Kara, will be a deadly fighter, but also one of the potential heirs to House Molay.

Now that she has a concept, Claire needs to choose a professional trait for Kara, and so picks 'Noble'. While Kara is a noblewoman, her Bene Gesserit training means she needs to choose the faction template for Bene Gesserit. Claire records the bonus trait 'Bene Gesserit' and notes that she will have to pick the talent 'Prana-bindu Conditioning' at some point.

BENE GESSERIT SISTER

But the Bene Gesserit ways were devious and compelling.

- Lady Jessica Atreides

Sisters of the Bene Gesserit are common among all levels of the nobility. The Sisterhood is often sought out to provide consorts, concubines, and advisors by the nobility. But Bene Gesserit adepts are also deadly fighters and highly perceptive and make exceptional spies and bodyguards. Many noble daughters are also sent for basic training with the Sisters as a form of 'finishing school'. Even if the House has not requested the Sisterhood to provide someone, the Bene Gesserit have been known to offer (or even insist on) providing one to a household. However, there is always an agenda behind the appointment, and nothing is ever free.

- **Additional Trait:** Bene Gesserit
- **Suggested Archetypes:** Analyst, Athlete, Courtier, Empath, Envoy, Infiltrator, Protector, Scholar, Spy, Warrior
- **Mandatory Talents:** Prana-bindu Conditioning



FREMEN

All of a man's water, ultimately, belongs to his people--to his tribe.

- Pardot Kynes

Exceptionally rare outside Arrakis, the desert Fremen are slow to give their loyalty to anyone outside their tribe, but once given it is absolute. Few, if any, leave Arrakis, but for those on the desert planet they are exceptional guides.

Fremen characters may only be played outside an Arrakis based campaign with the gamemaster's permission.

- ✧ **Additional Trait:** Fremen
- ✧ **Suggested Archetypes:** Athlete, Duelist, Infiltrator, Protector, Scout, Sergeant, Warrior
- ✧ **Mandatory Talents:** At least one of the following: Dedication, Driven, Master-at-arms, Rapid Recovery, Resilience (Battle), Subtle Step, The Reason I Fight, any of which may be taken in place of any other talent choice.



MENTAT

You do not withhold information or computation lines from a Mentat.

- Thufir Hawat

Adepts of the Mentat school are considered an essential asset to any House. While these 'human computers' are simply a convenient way to store data, most are trusted advisors at the highest levels of the Landsraad. Some Houses employ several Mentats, if only to 'backup data'.

- ✧ **Additional Trait:** Mentat
- ✧ **Suggested Archetypes:** Analyst, Empath, Envoy, Herald, Scholar, Spy, Steward, Strategist, Tactician
- ✧ **Mandatory Talents:** At least one of the following: Calculated Prediction, Mentat Discipline, Mind Palace, Twisted Mentat, Verify, any of which may be taken in place of any other talent choice.



SPACING GUILD AGENT

Power tends to isolate those who hold too much of it.

- Edric, Guild Steersman

While the elusive Navigators and Steersmen are never seen outside the Guild (and therefore cannot be player characters), the faction has agents across the universe. Guild agents are a point of contact for noble Houses wishing to travel or trade, and some are assigned to a noble House to maintain good relations and offer a priority service. They are also commonly assigned to any House that hosts a Guild facility (such as a bank) on their lands. However, a Guild agent is often more than just a point of contact. They also make excellent financial advisors, and while they cannot pilot a foldspace vessel, they are often experienced space travelers.

- ❖ **Additional Trait:** Guild Agent
- ❖ **Suggested Archetypes:** Analyst, Courtier, Envoy, Messenger, Scholar, Scout, Smuggler, Spy, Strategist
- ❖ **Mandatory Talents:** Guildsman



SUK DOCTOR

Great store is set on Imperial Conditioning.

- Piter De Vries

While there are many doctors and healers across the universe, the Suk doctors are considered the best. While they cost a fortune, anything they cannot cure, simply cannot be cured. They are also especially valuable to the nobility as their conditioning means they cannot cause any harm to their patients.

- ❖ **Additional Trait:** Suk Doctor
- ❖ **Suggested Archetypes:** Analyst, Commander, Courtier, Herald, Scholar, Steward
- ❖ **Mandatory Talents:** Imperial Conditioning



STEP TWO: ARCHETYPE

Next, select a general archetype for the character. These archetypes are designed to be relatively broad and cover a range of concepts, and it shouldn't be difficult to find an archetype that fits the concept you devised during step one. But if you still can't find something that fits, either change the theme of an archetype that has the right options or create a new archetype that matches what you are looking for. In both cases, make sure the gamemaster approves your choices.

In summary, each archetype provides:

- ❏ **Trait:** An archetype provides a single trait, representing the character's role or status, which will be the archetype's name. You may change or expand this if you wish, to something unique and befitting your concept, but the trait provided by your chosen archetype should serve as the basis for whatever you create.
- ❏ **Skills:** One skill is marked as primary, and one is marked as secondary. These skills will be increased in the next step.
- ❏ **Focuses:** The character receives two focuses for their primary or secondary skill. Suggestions for these are provided, but you may choose your own if you desire.
- ❏ **Talents:** The character receives a single talent. Suggestions for this are provided, but you may choose your own if you wish.

The archetypes also provide suggestions and ideas for what characters of that type will likely spend time doing and what they might believe. None of these suggestions are mandatory, but they can help when it comes to choosing the character's drives and ambitions later.

Example: *Claire looks through the suggested archetypes for a Bene Gesserit but decides to pick Commander as Kara's archetype instead. She likes the idea of Kara as a social character with fighting skills.*

ARCHETYPES AT A GLANCE

The archetypes are created to offer every combination of primary and secondary skill. If you already have a combination in mind for your concept, or want to add a different theme to a particular combination, the following table will help you find it.

Remember that some combinations might lend themselves to other styles of archetypes. While we have listed the combination of Communicate/Understand as a Courtier, they might just as easily apply to an Entertainer or Merchant instead.

ARCHETYPE	PRIMARY SKILL	SECONDARY SKILL
Analyst	Discipline	Understand
Athlete	Move	Discipline
Commander	Communicate	Battle
Courtier	Communicate	Understand
Duelist	Battle	Move
Empath	Understand	Communicate
Envoy	Communicate	Move
Herald	Discipline	Communicate
Infiltrator	Discipline	Move
Messenger	Move	Communicate
Protector	Discipline	Battle
Scholar	Understand	Discipline
Scout	Move	Understand
Sergeant	Battle	Communicate
Smuggler	Move	Battle
Spy	Understand	Move
Steward	Communicate	Discipline
Strategist	Understand	Battle
Tactician	Battle	Understand
Warrior	Battle	Discipline

BATTLE ARCHETYPES

WARMASTERS

One enemy at a time, is that it?

- Gurney Halleck

These archetypes all follow the code of war in some form. Some may consider martial skills to be a pathway to excellence; others might never use a weapon, focusing their mind on strategy and tactics instead. But all know what it is to fight and are lethal in one way or another.

DUELIST

Mastery of the blade is a valuable skill in the Imperium, and those who are especially capable are highly sought-after by the rulers of noble Houses, serving as bodyguards, champions, favored gladiators, and even tutors, teaching their skills to others in the House. Because of the prevalence of master duelists as instructors to the young scions of a House, many young nobles find themselves becoming duelists in their own right, even if only for a short while before they take on other courtly duties.

- ✧ **Trait:** Duelist
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Battle
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Move
- ✧ **Focuses:** Dueling, Short Blades
- ✧ **Talents:** The Slow Blade
- ✧ **Drives:** Duelists—particularly those who work as champions and bodyguards—are often believers in might makes right, feeling that Justice is enacted by their blades. Others are reliant on Faith—in their prowess, in their tools, or in a higher power—to keep them alive in their deadly profession.

SERGEANT

Amongst the rank-and-file troops of a House, and similarly amongst the various mercenary companies that drift from world to world, a select few stand out as leaders, earning the respect and loyalty of their subordinates. These sergeants are often practical people, hardened veterans who are accustomed to leading by example.

- ✧ **Trait:** Sergeant
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Battle
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Communicate
- ✧ **Focuses:** Long Blades, Strategy
- ✧ **Talents:** Master-at-Arms
- ✧ **Drives:** Sergeants commonly feel a strong bond of loyalty to their warriors, one which is reciprocated and manifests in a powerful sense of Duty. Others are driven by a strong sense of right and wrong, and a strong drive in Justice.

TACTICIAN

Where a strategist orchestrates the grand plan of battle, tacticians direct the fighting on a smaller scale. A mercenary company, or a House regiment, may have a handful of tactical experts, who drill and train the rank and file and officers alike to hone their responses to particular situations. When pressed into battle themselves, they're cunning, resourceful combatants, often able to see opportunities that less-astute fighters might miss.

- ✧ **Trait:** Tactician
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Battle
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Understand
- ✧ **Focuses:** Combat Awareness, Tactics
- ✧ **Talents:** Decisive Action
- ✧ **Drives:** Tacticians are well-versed in the proper and effective use of force, and thus understand Power extremely well. Many also see their causes as right and proper, and the execution of their duties as a matter of Justice.

WARRIOR

Might at arms is a necessary part of the politics of the Imperium. While restrained by the traditions and rules of klanly, each House maintains a standing army for defending its people and territory, for putting down rebellions and insurrections from within, and for waging wars against enemies. Mercenary companies hire out their services to any able to pay, often bolstering House forces. Warriors hail from such armed forces, and the most capable amongst them tend to gain prominence and status, often joining elite units or the personal guard of important persons outside the House.

- ✧ **Trait:** Warrior
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Battle
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Discipline
- ✧ **Focuses:** Dirty Fighting, Long Blade
- ✧ **Talents:** To Fight Someone Is to Know Them
- ✧ **Drives:** Warriors often put their trust in their own prowess and capabilities, and thus prioritize Power. Others tend to emphasize the need to use their skills for a good reason, focusing on Justice.

COMMUNICATE ARCHETYPES

SOCIALITES

Reputation can be a beautiful weapon. It often spills less blood.

- Bashar Miles Teg

These archetypes are the social characters, at their best when surrounded by others. They might be manipulative courtiers or inspirational leaders. Whatever their angle, they are adept at getting their own way and manipulating others.

COMMANDER

Commanders are senior leaders of military forces; their role is to decide upon a plan of action and give orders to their subordinates. Some serve as commanding officers over detachments of troops, or leaders of mercenary companies, while others are freelance strategists hired to help guide a standing army. Many Houses often employ a Warmaster as a dedicated commander for their troops.

- ✧ **Trait:** Commander
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Communicate
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Battle
- ✧ **Focuses:** Inspiration, Leadership
- ✧ **Talents:** Specialist (Warfare Assets)
- ✧ **Drives:** Many Commanders are driven by a sense of Duty and loyalty to their superiors and the chain of command, while others are ambitious, seeking Power and opportunities to elevate themselves.

COURTIER

Courtiers are the assorted attendants, advisors, clerks, agents, and others with positions at court, or access to the rulers of the House. Not all who have a position at court will be of this archetype—those who attend court because of their knowledge or prowess in other fields, such as soldiers, may fit other archetypes better. Trusted courtiers are skilled speakers and listeners, for access and knowledge are the advantages of the courtier, and they are often at the forefront of palace intrigues.

- ✧ **Trait:** Courtier
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Communicate
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Understand
- ✧ **Focuses:** Charm, Musical Instrument
- ✧ **Talents:** Subtle Words
- ✧ **Drives:** Courtiers tend to be ambitious, seeking the influence and Power that their positions at court can provide, but those courtiers who are rewarded with their masters' trust are those who are driven by a sense of Duty and loyalty.

ENVOY

Representatives of their employers in negotiations and diplomacy, envoys are charged with traveling from place to place, conveying the will and words of their masters wherever it is required. By necessity, envoys are well-traveled and used to long journeys and rough conditions, and they need to be quick-witted and quick on their feet to survive the perils of their vocation.

- ✧ **Trait:** Envoy
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Communicate
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Move
- ✧ **Focuses:** Diplomacy, Persuasion
- ✧ **Talents:** Binding Promise
- ✧ **Drives:** A trusted Envoy will often have a strong sense of Duty, which may shape why they choose to serve in that capacity. Other envoys have a strong sense of Justice and a reputation for fairness which helps their work.

STEWARD

The running of a House is a complex, burdensome matter, and those who rule over each House typically delegate many of those tasks and responsibilities to trusted subordinates. These stewards manage the day-to-day operations of the House, overseeing some aspect of it in their master's name. These individuals are capable, decisive, and good at organizing people, because anything less would be unacceptable. A House will have numerous stewards, with more in Houses with larger holdings, and many are given considerable autonomy to take whatever actions they need to in order to keep things running smoothly.

- ✧ **Trait:** Steward
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Communicate
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Discipline
- ✧ **Focuses:** Leadership, Negotiation
- ✧ **Talents:** Stirring Rhetoric
- ✧ **Drives:** Stewards are often chosen from amongst those who prioritize Duty above all else, so long as their dutiful nature is accompanied by sufficient competence. Many stewards are also highly ambitious individuals, seeking to gain status, recognition, and ultimately, Power from their work.

DISCIPLINE ARCHETYPES

DISCIPLES

One observes the survivors and learns from them.

- Bene Gesserit Teaching

These archetypes seek to master an internal stillness where they function with perfect grace and clarity. They are exceptionally focused and dedicated, having honed their skills through practice and intense training.

ANALYST

Analysts are often in the employ of noble Houses to study the details and trends of business, politics, and warfare—and the points at which those three things blur into one another—and the most skilled are highly-prized. Mentats are especially valuable as analysts, due to their ability to process vast amounts of information quickly and dispassionately.

- ☞ **Trait:** Analyst
- ☞ **Primary Skill:** Discipline
- ☞ **Secondary Skill:** Understand
- ☞ **Focuses:** Attention to Detail, Composure
- ☞ **Talents:** Intense Study
- ☞ **Drives:** Many Analysts are driven by a strong drive to uncover or reveal the Truth, while those trusted with the secrets of their employers are ones who believe strongly in Duty.

HERALD

Many Houses in the Landsraad appoint ceremonial officers to handle matters of heraldry, genealogy, and similar matters of rank and pedigree: these are matters of the long-term survival of the House. These officers serve mainly as advisors to the House's rulers on these matters, and they frequently consult with the Sisters of the Bene Gesserit who maintain similar genealogical and genetic records. Heralds often fulfil other roles within a Household alongside their official duties, at times serving as messengers, diplomats, and political advisors.

- ☞ **Trait:** Herald
- ☞ **Primary Skill:** Discipline
- ☞ **Secondary Skill:** Communicate
- ☞ **Focuses:** Command, Composure
- ☞ **Talents:** Rigorous Control
- ☞ **Drives:** A Herald will often have Faith in a greater plan or purpose for their House, and Duty is often a common drive for those appointed to such important roles.

INFILTRATOR

Skilled at finding their way into secure places, infiltrators are an important part of the interplay between Houses and the other great organizations of the Imperium: politics would be drastically different were it not for the subterfuge and espionage that occurs on a daily basis. Infiltrators require boundless resolve and focus, maintaining a clear sense of their goals and their loyalties as they undertake their work.

- ☞ **Trait:** Infiltrator
- ☞ **Primary Skill:** Discipline
- ☞ **Secondary Skill:** Move
- ☞ **Focuses:** Infiltration, Precision
- ☞ **Talents:** Subtle Step
- ☞ **Drives:** Infiltrators often discover their vocation through a powerful sense of curiosity and a need to discover the Truth, while others revel in the Power they can claim through the secrets they find.

PROTECTOR

Security is a must for anyone of wealth and status, and protectors are those most capable of providing that. Any House will contain a cadre of trained bodyguards and security personnel to secure the House's grounds and protect its members and senior agents. These are distinct from ordinary House troops, as they practice greater restraint and self-awareness, and have an unyielding resolve; they will continue to protect their charges after most soldiers have lost their nerve, and they prioritize the safety of their charges above glory in battle.

- ☞ **Trait:** Protector
- ☞ **Primary Skill:** Discipline
- ☞ **Secondary Skill:** Battle
- ☞ **Focuses:** Resolve, Self-Control
- ☞ **Talents:** Bolster
- ☞ **Drives:** Protectors are commonly chosen because of a strong sense of Duty; many are instead driven by a powerful belief in Justice.